

Checklist:

Hiring Checklist

Set up before you hire

- ☐ Treat hiring as one of the highest-leverage things you do.
- ☐ View hiring as building the future of the team, not just filling holes.
- ☐ Plan ahead instead of hiring reactively.
- ☐ Map where you want the team to be by year-end.
- ☐ Identify skill, strength, and experience gaps on the team.
- ☐ Decide what kinds of people would strengthen team diversity.
- ☐ Define the level and scope for each open role.

Own the hiring process

- ☐ Take personal responsibility for hiring, even if you have recruiters.
- ☐ Write the job description yourself.
- ☐ Be specific about the skills and experiences you want.
- ☐ Partner closely with recruiting on sourcing, interviewing, and closing.
- ☐ Help craft outreach that feels personal and relevant.

Build the candidate pipeline

- ☐ Create a sourcing strategy before you start interviewing.
- ☐ List target backgrounds, companies, titles, and keywords.
- ☐ Look beyond standard patterns when searching for talent.
- ☐ Ask trusted people for recommendations.
- ☐ Use references as a meaningful signal, not a box-checking step.
- ☐ Keep in mind that old negative feedback may be outdated.

Run a strong interview process

- ☐ Make the interview experience attentive, focused, and fast.
- ☐ Coordinate tightly with recruiters and interviewers.
- ☐ Prepare interview questions ahead of time.
- ☐ Ask every candidate a consistent core set of questions.

- ☐ Tailor additional questions to the role's actual needs.
- ☐ Include multiple interviewers with different perspectives.
- ☐ Ensure interviewers assess different dimensions, not the same one repeatedly.
- ☐ Debrief independently before group discussion to avoid groupthink.

Ask better questions

- ☐ Probe for examples of similar past work.
- ☐ Ask candidates to show real output: apps, writing, pitches, portfolios, etc.
- ☐ Clarify what part of teamwork they personally owned.
- ☐ Ask what kinds of challenges excite them.
- ☐ Ask about strengths, areas for growth, and self-awareness.
- ☐ Ask where they want to be in five years.
- ☐ Ask about a hard conflict and what they learned.
- ☐ Ask what has inspired them lately.

Make better decisions

- ☐ Remember, interviews are imperfect and often noisy.
- ☐ Don't rely only on gut feel from a short interview.
- ☐ Watch for personal bias in evaluation.
- ☐ Avoid "weak hire" decisions.
- ☐ Look for at least one strong, passionate advocate.
- ☐ Reject candidates who show toxic behavior.
- ☐ Favor candidates who can grow beyond the current role.
- ☐ Prioritize people who raise the team's long-term capability.

Prioritize diversity and perspective

- ☐ Intentionally seek candidates with different backgrounds and viewpoints.
- ☐ Avoid hiring only people who look, think, and work like the current team.
- ☐ Recognize that diverse teams make better decisions and produce better ideas.

Close candidates well

- ☐ Make candidates feel genuinely wanted.
- ☐ Move quickly once you decide to make an offer.
- ☐ Stay involved during the closing process.
- ☐ Explain why the role matters and why they are a strong fit.
- ☐ Paint a compelling picture of the impact they could have.

- ☐ Keep communication warm, clear, and frequent.

Hire at scale

- ☐ Understand your funnel metrics from outreach to offer acceptance.
- ☐ Expect hiring to require volume and repetition.
- ☐ Break the process into manageable parts and improve each one.
- ☐ Train interviewers to assess candidates consistently.
- ☐ Build systems, not one-off heroic efforts.
- ☐ Spend substantial time on hiring when team growth is a priority.

Hire leaders carefully

- ☐ Do extra research before hiring managers or senior leaders.
- ☐ Learn what great candidates for that leadership role look like.
- ☐ Involve people who understand the function deeply.
- ☐ Assess values alignment, not just competence.
- ☐ Treat leadership hiring as a long-term investment.

Play the long game

- ☐ Build relationships with great people before roles open.
- ☐ Keep in touch with strong candidates who say no.
- ☐ Invest in your network and team reputation over time.
- ☐ Remember that careers are long and timing changes.

Build a hiring culture

- ☐ Share responsibility for hiring across leaders as the team grows.
- ☐ Coach others on what great talent looks like.
- ☐ Set a high bar and repeat it often.
- ☐ Make team-building everyone's job.
- ☐ Create a culture that consistently prioritizes hiring well.

